HISTORY





Courtesy: LHAMO TSERING ARCHIVE

ON A WAR FOOTING

An exhibition in Delhi tells the story of how some Tibetans had once taken up arms to fight China



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After China invaded Tibet in 1950, 'sporadic armed resistance' started springing up across the country, and when these factions later united, they together came to be known as the Chushi Gangdruk army. Interestingly, these events all unfolded during the Cold War, when the US wanted to contain the spread of communism. So, when the resistance fighters sought support, the CIA both trained them and funded their movement. This secret operation, which ran from 1957 to 1970, was code-named STCIRCUS. This little-known chapter in history is the subject of Ritu Sarin and Tenzing Sonam's exhibition *Shadow Circus: A Personal Archive of Tibetan Resistance (1957–1974)*. Organised with curator Natasha Ginwala, it is on view at India International Centre's Art Gallery in Delhi till May 1.



RAISA GALOFRE

Shadow Circus includes material that Sarin and Sonam have gathered since they started researching the topic in the late 1980s. Inspiration to do so first came from Sonam's late father, Lhamo Tsering, a key figure in the resistance and its main liaison with the CIA. "He was a meticulous archivist who kept detailed records of the resistance, including photographs, maps, documents and letters," says Sonam, via email. The centrepiece of the exhibition is a re-edited version of the 1998 documentary film *The Shadow Circus: The CIA in Tibet* that saw Sonam and Sarin interview former fighters and CIA officers. Contacting the latter, Sarin says, was especially hard: "Tenzing's father knew them only by their first names...

SHADOW CIRCUS HAS ON DISPLAY CIA-ISSUED MAPS AND DRAWINGS FROM THE GUERRILLA HAND-BOOK MADE BY TIBETAN TRAINEES AT CAMP HALE